

Chapter 68: Art that Heals: Tracing Catharsis in Poems on Pestilence

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Abstract

Poetry has become a medium to articulate the hopes and worries of the strange times in which we are living. Literature, particularly poetry has provided solace during outbreaks of pandemic by sharing both the personal and collective angst of human psyche. Catharsis acts as a balancing process amidst such uncertain ages through the release of mental conflicts to reach an emotional equilibrium. This study “Art that Heals: Tracing Catharsis in Poems on Pestilence” tries to figure out catharsis as a healing process by considering three poems about pandemic from different points of time.

Keywords: Poetry, Pandemic, Catharsis, Reader, Writer

1. Introduction

In times of pestilence, poetry has always been a source of solace. When it comes to poets, poetry provides a private space to alleviate the mental trauma of living through tough days, while for the millions of readers, it is a place where they can identify themselves with. In reality, what is the purpose of creating poems during plagues and pestilences? Was it for holding up the responsibility of an artist to store the pathos of the day within the eternal urn of poesy? Or was art a means of communication to relieve the agonized psyche of the creator? Answers to these questions may vary but it is quite certain that poets “exploited” poetry amidst plagues and pestilences to relieve themselves from the pressures of their day. Incontrovertibly, readers also attain a sense of comfort when they discover their anxieties being addressed via the medium of poetry. That is, the poet by practicing art and the reader by consuming it, experience the process of catharsis eventually in this context. Catharsis is a concept generally associated with the Greek philosopher Aristotle (384 BC- 322 BC) who used the term while elaborating the aspects of tragedy:

Tragedy, then, is an imitation of an action that is serious, complete, and of a certain magnitude; in language embellished with each kind of artistic ornament, the several kinds being found in separate parts of the play; in the form of action, not of narrative; through pity and fear effecting the proper purgation of these emotions. (Poetics VI, 1449b24-28)

To expound catharsis in poems on pestilence, the first poem I analysed here is “A Litany in Time of Plague” by Thomas Nashe, written during the bubonic plague outbreak in 1592 that devastated England. The second poem, “CHOLERA-1853” written by James Reynolds Withers depicts the cholera pandemic of the nineteenth century. The third and last poem, “Shades of Lockdown” by Ashwani Kumar is an insightful exploration of the COVID -19 pandemic days.

These three poems are examined in accord with the fact that catharsis is the purgation of unpleasant emotions, like pity and fear, which can refine the minds of the participants involved in the process. In case of the poet, here catharsis is taken in a broader sense rather than in the traditional definition, as it seems more relevant to the context. This paper humbly attempts at reminiscing the cathartic function of art that has always enlightened our past and that which continues to this day, hopefully.

2. Cathartic Function of Poems on Pestilence: A Study of Three Poems

I. "A Litany in Time of Plague"- Thomas Nashe

The sceptre that haunted Europe for years was none other than the bubonic plague. The Black Death that ravaged the Eurasia in the fourteenth century has rewritten the history of world in many ways. In sixteenth century, England witnessed another destructive outbreak of bubonic plague in London from 1592 to 1593 in which thousands of people lost their lives. It was amid these difficult times, Thomas Nashe (1567-1601) wrote the poem "A Litany in Time of Plague". Nashe was one of the versatile figures of Elizabethan era acclaimed as a dramatist, poet, satirist and pamphleteer.

Centring upon the theme of mortality, "A Litany in Time of Plague" reflects upon the turmoil of the period suffering the wrath of the malignant sickness. The lyric begins with bidding farewell to the transient world, "Adieu, farewell, earth's bliss; / this world uncertain is;" (Nashe, lines 1-2). The speaker reminds us about the futility of life's pleasures at a time of vulnerability, "Fond are life's lustful joys; / Death proves them all but toys; / None from his darts can fly;" (3-5).

Plague forced the speaker to get obsessed with the thoughts of doom like any other (un)fortunate human being of his day, "The inevitable death is exempting none as he mourns, "Strength stoops unto the grave, / Worms feed on Hector brave;" (22-23). The poem envisions that all are fated to yield when the Grim Reaper arrives with his scythe, "Wit with his wantonness / Tasted death's bitterness;" (29-30). The refrain, "I am sick, I must die. / Lord, have mercy on us!" is used in order to express the utter depression and agony of a period clouded by contagion. Towards the end, Nashe emphasizes the limited excursion of human kind in this illusory world:

Heaven is our heritage,

Earth but a player's stage;

Mount us unto the sky.

I am sick, I must die.

Lord, have mercy on us! (38-42)

Nashe has captured the traumatic realities of the plague evocatively. But was this act in some way advantageous to the poet? Before answering, first of all, it is to be noted that being a victim of an erratic and uncanny period, he was endeavouring to translate his pain and grief into the language of poetry. For readers, the poem has definitely awakened some of their pre-existing fears regarding the transience of life. That is, the poem has brought some of the concealed vexations of the readers like pity and fear to their consciousness, which was till then awaiting an exposure to get revealed and resolved.

Accordingly, we identify with the sufferers but from a safe distance which is relieving as well as eye-opening. Not only the new realization uplifts the readers rationally but also eliminates the incited

emotions of pity and fear. The poem delivers emotional catharsis with a profound sense of empathy shared between author and readers.

II. “CHOLERA -1853”- James Reynolds Withers

One of the nightmares that terrorised the world throughout the nineteenth century was cholera pandemic. The poem “CHOLERA -1853” by James Reynolds Withers (1812-92) sheds light on the cholera outbreak that crept through the England as a part of the third cholera pandemic from 1846 to 1860. Withers was a gifted rural poet from Fordham whose works brim with the beauty and charm of his countryside. “CHOLERA -1853” is included in his *POEMS UPON VARIOUS SUBJECTS* published in 1854. Through the poem, Withers expose the degradation of his land and its inhabitants under the King Cholera's sway.

“CHOLERA -1853” personifies the gruesome pestilence satirically. The harbinger of death announces, “I’m coming, I’m coming, the scourge of mankind: / I float on the waters, I ride on the wind; / Gaunt hunger and squalor prepare my dread way;” (Withers, lines 1-3). Cholera has become ubiquitous and as usual, the poverty-stricken are the worst affected, “In the homes of the wretched my sceptre I sway” (4). The contagion exploded vigorously in areas lacking proper sanitation facilities, “In filthy damp alleys and courts I rein / o’er the dark stagnant pool and putrid drain:” (5-6). These realities are beyond terrifying but Withers show that the “king” continues his rule over the ill- fated kingdom:

I take the infant to-day from the breast-

To-morrow the mother with grief distresses –

The father with care and toil oppress

I send the next day where the weary rest. (11-14)

The poem reminds that similar to any other pandemic, the wreckage of human relations is visible here too, “The dearest friends asunder I part; / and I laugh at the skill of the healing art” (15-16). An air of apprehension and anguish pervades the scenario, “The yawning grave and the tolling bell; / the nightly unfollow’d funeral;” (17-18). The liveliness of the land has disappeared, “The houses forsaken; the grass-grown green / Where the bounding step of health had been” (19-20). Finally, cholera proclaims the slaughter of the masses boastfully, “Tell the havoc I make, for to none do I bow, / But to him who appointeth how far I shall go” (23-24).

Withers opens up the grievous actualities of the turbulent times in its full intensity. Writing becomes therapeutic as the “possibilities of poetry reveal themselves over and over by breaking through the silence of our hidden thoughts and lived experiences of pain ... bringing into presence our inner reflective thinking, emotions, and self-empathy to help ourselves and others who suffer alongside us” (Hovey et al.). His aesthetic endeavours to carve out a poem from the miseries of his day, up to an extent, replace the pain of life with the pleasure of art, which is cathartic in its quintessence.

The poem expresses “what is universal in the form of particular or “historical” events [and] [t]his process of observing or inferring the universal character implied in the individual is the process of

learning and is by nature a source of pleasure to mankind” (Golden 54) . Their minds are back to normality and are refreshed as a result of lustrating the negative emotions. Catharsis therefore becomes a function of the poem.

III. “Shades of Lockdown” - Ashwani Kumar

As the corona virus evolved into a global phenomenon synonymous with fear, frenzy and suspicion, the world was passing through a monumental phase in the history of human survival. COVID -19 rewrote the definitions of many of the things we had once taken for granted. This unfamiliar and strange period is addressed in the poem “Shades of Lockdown” by Ashwani Kumar, where he reproduces the stark actualities of the people living through a pandemic. Kumar, a distinguished Indian poet and writer, infuses the various dimensions of social disruption he observes as a citizen of the nation where lakhs have already been martyred.

From the very first line itself, “Shades of Lockdown” tells us about the furious conquest of virus, “In a sudden invasion / an invisible pathogen infects air sacs, / and paralyses all forms of life on the earth” (Kumar, lines 1-3). The tragic happenings across the world are sketched out, “Corpses rise, funeral processions march / Limb by limb” (9-10). The soaring death toll indicates the insufficient medical facilities provided by the society, “Facing acute shortage of hospital beds and ventilators / Priests in white aprons sacrifices bearded / handsome alligators in balcony prayers” (13-15).

Kumar describes the bleakness of living a life of prohibitions and restrictions, “I hear sounds of the angry silence of office goers and travellers / Locked down in their fossil homes, / Barbecuing, sailing to their fantasy destinations” (22-24). Along with these issues, the tribulations of the marginalized people stain the claims of equity and equality the society has achieved. The miserable condition of the working classes make their condition even worse, “Starving vagrant labourers / Craving for a religious past / or easing of secular isolation restrictions,” (25-27).

The poem conveys that hopes will fade and nightmares will often accompany the days and nights during such catastrophes. But the poet cannot help from believing in the return of hope someday, “But it is beautiful early summer / I am not marooned of hope - / the beastly fear slowly annihilates itself” (33-35). Finally, Kumar wraps up the poem optimistically:

With scents of smouldering wet sandalwood, and

Life regains its glowing fire –

Stirring poem after poem

In the ancient clay pot of ashes. (36-39)

From the poem, it is visible that in days of utter despair and isolation, poetry serves as a companion, especially to the poet, by existing as a portal to self-expression. For the poet, poetry communicates the self and is thus entirely restorative. For readers, it leads to self- enquiry and introspection, driving them to

an enlightened understanding about the causes of such emotions. Besides, a poem “liberates man from the passivity of blind feelings and also from his self- isolation and gives him a taste of his essential self that is active and lucid in knowledge and is social” (Chaudhury 222). This revelation exempt the readers from the perturbing emotions by far aroused, directing to a relaxed and restored state of mind. Hence, the poem “Shades of Lockdown” unburdens the soul through words by acting as an emotional purge.

3. CONCLUSION

The long tradition of poetry about plagues and pestilences not just represent the bleak realities of the ages but hold the potential to facilitate catharsis to the poets and readers. In regard to this fact, this paper attempted at unfolding the curative nature of poems on pestilences by explicating three poems from different centuries. Further, this paper ascertains that these poetic works act as an antidote to the trials and tribulations of pandemic times. Art always functioned as a therapy during challenging times by aiding the poets and readers with a universe of its own. Ultimately, this paper, written during the cataclysmic phase of the coronavirus pandemic, has demonstrated its true relevance and accentuated the restorative power of poetry in times of global crisis.

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